



“Private **affluence** amid public **squalor**.”

J. K. GALBRAITH, US ECONOMIST, ON THE DISCREPANCIES IN AMERICAN SOCIETY IN “THE AFFLUENT SOCIETY,” 1958



Eating out

With increased disposable income, young couples could spend money on recreation, drinking after work, or eating out regularly at the local diner. Such facilities were, however, still segregated in many southern states.

principles to his first development of 2,000 two-bedroom houses for war veterans on Long Island. Each house cost \$6,900, with no down payment for veterans and a mortgage guaranteed by a federal housing bill. Levittown, as it became known, grew in four years to 17,447 houses and a population of 82,000 people. There were some rules: no fences, no clotheslines, no shrubs more than 4 ft (1.2 m) high along the lot line, and, controversially, no African-Americans, although that exclusion ended in 1949. The houses were all identical, but their inhabitants soon personalized them, adding porches and patios and building extra rooms. Some 13 million new homes were built from

1948 to 1958, almost all of them in new suburbs. This turned many American cities into social doughnuts, with a rich commercial and business

center surrounded by a poor, largely African-American-inhabited inner ring of social housing, surrounded in turn by largely white suburbs.

Teen culture

As America grew richer, it also got younger: 40 million Americans were born from 1950 to 1960. By 1964, 40 percent of the population was under 20. The idea of the “teenager” emerged as young people developed their own culture.

Popular music had been divided according to race and, partly, class. Crooners dominated white popular music with movie and musical hits. Country and western was popular among the white working class, while African-Americans had blues, gospel, and, in the late 1940s, rhythm and blues. A new hybrid music—merging African-American rhythm and blues and white country and western—by white singers Bill Haley in 1954 and Elvis Presley in 1956, gave young people their own music. Rock ‘n’ roll was the music of rebellion and teenage angst, echoed in the movies of James Dean and Marlon Brando. It fed the emerging counterculture. Jazz, the Beat poets, novelists like Jack Kerouac, abstract expressionists Jackson Pollock and Mark Rothko, and folk and protest songs of Woody Guthrie and, later, Bob Dylan, defined American culture as much as rock ‘n’ roll or movies.

Suburbia

The mass production of housing resulted in streets with row after row of identical houses. Singer Malvina Reynolds critiqued the 1950s blandness with her song “Little Boxes,” in which she sang “Little boxes on the hillside, ... Little boxes all the same ... And they’re all made out of ticky tacky and they all look just the same.”

The flip side

The American dream was not enjoyed by everyone. The 1950s was a conservative decade, based on white, middle-class family values where men went to work and wives stayed at home—only 36 percent of women worked in 1955. Women shared the dream, but relied on men to create it. African-Americans had no such dream.

Segregation in jobs, housing, education, and democratic rights was rife, most notably in Southern states. The country was also in the grip of

the Cold War (see pp. 406–07), giving rise to internal troubles such as the McCarthy witch-hunts (see below).

MCCARTHYISM The practice, named after Senator Joe McCarthy, of accusing individuals of belonging to the Communist Party or communist organizations despite little supporting evidence. It raised fears of a “red menace” against American society in the Cold War.



Senator McCarthy

In 1950, the senator from Wisconsin alleged he had the names of 547 card-carrying communists in the State Department, and another 205 communist sympathizers. His anticommunist witch-hunt struck a chord as the Cold War with Russia intensified, but when he attacked the army in 1954 he was censured by the Senate.



Jazz music

After the artistic excesses of Charlie Parker and bop music in the 1940s, 1950s jazz cooled down to find a new audience, with musicians like trumpeter Miles Davis (above) and college circuit favorite, pianist Dave Brubeck.

AFTER

In the 1960s and 1970s the reality of the “dream” was laid bare.

VIETNAM

The 1950s American dream became a nightmare in the 1960s, as arguments about civil rights **434–35** and increasing opposition to the Vietnam War **430–31** led to race riots and mass demonstrations in many cities. What appeared to be a cohesive, affluent society was revealed as divisive and fractured along lines of race and class.

IMMIGRANTS

The idea of the American dream is still powerful for many Hispanic immigrants. However, the reality is often harsh. Many immigrants work in seasonal jobs with low pay and few prospects.



LATINO (HISPANIC) WORKERS